

NAPLES ITALY



Perfect Pizza in Buzzing Naples

The bustling southern Italian city of Naples may at first seem chaotic, but visitors quickly fall under the spell of this underappreciated gem and its rich artistic heritage. Naples is quintessential Mediterranean Italy, and as a region it's famous for its delicious tomatoes and outstanding mozzarella cheese, so it's not surprising that it's also the undisputed "home of the pizza."



A sprawling city of dramatic contrasts, Naples displays its regal past in the shape of impressive castles and magnificent palaces erected by Spanish and Bourbon

rulers from the 16th to the 19th centuries. But the city is best known for a more ancient event – the eruption of Vesuvius in AD 79. Still visible across the waters of the Bay of Naples, the volcano submerged the neighboring Roman city of Pompeii in yards of ash and debris, wiping out its entire population.

Amazingly, the narrow streets of the historic heart of modern-day Naples still correspond to an ancient Greek-Roman grid. In this maze, life spills out into the public domain – people call to each other from windows, scooters zoom along doing their best to dodge pedestrians, and minuscule shops, neighborhood churches, and cafés juggle for precious space. Just as in centuries past, a lot of eating takes place outside, with food bought from open-air stands and glass-fronted kiosks displaying tempting wares. The vast array of "fast" street food includes sweet and savory treats, from sugary doughnuts and crispy chunks of

potato to fried *arancini* rice balls stuffed with minced meat. There's even fried wrap-over pizza, though this oil-drenched snack is not to everyone's liking.

Originally fare for the poor, pizza has long been the flagship of Italian cuisine across the world. There are countless fanciful international toppings, but the most famous pizza of all is the classic Margherita. Invented by Neapolitan chef Raffaello Esposito in 1889 to honor a visiting Italian queen and the recently unified nation, it features the colors of the nation's flag: white (cheese), red (locally grown San Marzano tomatoes), and green (basil). Today, pizza marinara is a close favorite, its anchovies jostling for attention among black olives, garlic, and sometimes capers.

Without a doubt, the best place to enjoy a pizza is at one of the numerous family-run pizzerias in Naples, which fill the air with an irresistible fragrance of sizzling mozzarella and fresh San Marzano tomatoes bubbling under a drizzle of Campania olive oil and a sprinkling of native oregano. Whatever the topping, there is complete agreement on how the pizza is to be consumed – immediately and on the spot.



Above Naples is spread out along the Bay of Naples, overlooked by Vesuvius

What Else to Eat

Naples is also famous for its rich cakes and heavenly desserts, and the city has a mouthwatering choice of *pasticceria*, where freshly baked sweet delights are showcased in glass-topped counters. *Sfogliatelle* are shell-shaped, layered pastries flavored with vanilla and filled with a mixture of delicate ricotta cheese and morsels of candied orange. The epitome of sugar heaven is a *babà al rum*, a mushroom-shaped sponge cake drenched in rum syrup and smothered in whipped cream. Probably introduced to Naples by the French cooks at court, it was created by an 18th-century Polish king, who named it after Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves, stories about whom he adored. Another special treat is a slice of *pastiera napoletana*, a celebratory Easter pie baked with ricotta cheese, candied citrus fruits, and spices.

The Best Places to Eat Pizza

Antica Pizzeria Da Michele

inexpensive

The bare marble table tops and stark tiled walls don't put off the constant stream of diners who flock to this highly popular and long-standing Neapolitan establishment. Neither do the long lines. Everyone knows it's well worth the wait, and there's a mouthwatering aroma to keep you company in the street. When your number is called, you're given a table amid jovial groups of families and friends. The choice of liquid refreshment is limited to soft drinks, water, or beer, all served in plastic cups. And ordering your meal doesn't take long either, as it's a simple choice between just two pizzas: the Marinara or the Margherita. Both are spread with *passato* (puréed) San Marzano tomatoes from the nearby Sarno Valley and topped with a fresh, smooth *fiore di latte* cow's milk mozzarella from Agerola on the Amalfi coast. The huge, soft pizzas are served steaming straight from the oven, for delicious, immediate consumption.

Via Cesare Sersale, Naples; open 10 AM–11 PM Mon–Sat; www.damichele.net

Also in Naples

Antica Pizzeria de Borgo Orefici (+39 81 552 0996; moderate) is a simple, family-run establishment tucked away down a narrow street that was once the heart of the goldsmiths' district. It has many faithful diners and the place can get busy. Toppings are generous and pizzas include *miseria e nobiltà*: a catch-all pizza that's half marinara and half Margherita.

Also in Italy

Muro Frari (www.murovinoecucina.it; moderate) at San Polo 2604 in Venice is a modern restaurant offering gourmet pizzas with all manner of treats, such as porcini mushrooms, fresh buffalo mozzarella, and smoked swordfish and tuna. Don't miss the delicious apéritifs with seasonal fresh fruit and sparkling Prosecco, which can be enjoyed outside in summer.

Around the World

Long lines form outside **Grimaldi's Pizzeria (www.grimaldis.com; inexpensive)** at the foot of the Brooklyn Bridge in New York. Regulars rub shoulders with celebrities among the trademark red-and-white check tablecloths. It's the coal-brick oven here that gives the pizzas their sought-after crisp crust and smoky flavor. A long list of toppings allows you to invent your very own pizza with your favorite flavors. In the UK, **Santoré (www.santorerestaurant.co.uk; inexpensive)** in London serves outstandingly good, authentic Neapolitan pizzas in lively Exmouth Market.